

GAMING ARCHIVES RESEARCH

INTERVIEW SERIES OF INTERNATIONAL
MEDIA LIBRARY POLICY FOR VGHF

Solon Scott | University of Washington | JULY 18, 2026

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FIVE INTERVIEWS

The following essays were written from interviews held with five professional archivists ranging between private, public, and non-profit universities. Each interview was inspiring and foundational for authoring the collection development policy that was built alongside this document. They each illuminate unique ways policies are guiding how digital and physical videogames are being stewarded including what services are being offered, what needs are unique to games, how our rules are defining the identity of videogames, and how we can continue to develop this nascent field together in power. I am thankful for the conversations shared with these archivists:

Virginia Allison-Reinhardt - Blizzard Games Archives

Chris Arneil - National Film and Sound Archive of Australia

David Pierce - Media History Digital Library

William Hilhorst - Netherlands Institute of Sound and Video + EFGAMP

Natalia Kovalainen - Embracer Games Archive

THE ROLE OF LIBRARIANS IN THE GAMES PIPELINE

Interview with Virginia Allison-Reinhardt - Blizzard Games Archives

Blizzard's archives have stood the test of time. They were built during a time when archives were seen as a sign of a professionalizing tech and media corporation in LA in the 00s and have survived two decades of tech mergers to now hold a collection spanning 30-years. In archive terms that's a blink-of-an-eye, yet with the Microsoft Library shutting down Blizzard's staff house one of the most weathered, veteran archive teams in the industry. They have built a selection of services that entrench them as an important organ within the ever increasing ABK system, with Virginia calling the archive "...a soul of Blizzard".

Services Mentioned:

- Library of artbooks, design books, inspiring literature, contemporary games.
- Private Tours of Blizzard
- Third space, community hub, and filming location
- Archiving work - opt in for people's work, not mandated
- Presenting library services to individual teams and stakeholders
- Cultural trades with other corporate archives annually (E.g., games, software, media, historical)
- Cultural celebrations - Museum exhibits aligned with project launches!

Virginia's Current Motivators:

- Current Project: API access with pipeline
- The Dream Goal: A physical lab for game research

These services have historically been provided, iterated on, and expanded with documentation around annual strategies, values, and mission statements. Only recently have they begun incorporating official policy documentation for the archive's services. They are now realizing the importance of this level of documentation, with Virginia describing how "the collection development policy protects the archive's relationships within and around Blizzard. Thus ensuring that teams are on the same page and can trust in their services to assist them." This requires a focus on non-specialist readability to inform how they wrote their policy, which inspired the approach for creating the VGHF's documentation to enhance readability and comprehension of the materials for digital archive users.

Blizzard's incredible. I can't believe I get to report this: They don't collect material when the project is done anymore, they collect it and archive it *alongside development!* Team members will upload their development materials to the engine Blizzard Archives calls the Blizzard Art Resource Tool (BART). The artist also applies the initial metadata and manages their revisions directly inside of BART. Expanding their library team increased metadata capture from about 20% to 100% of their 5+ million finished project materials, allowing for immediate cross-team and library support for new objects submitted by employees. Since BART is actively stewarded by the archive team, it's clear that Blizzard's librarians being attached to the development pipeline gives strong strategic advantage. They are like those cool striped suckerfish you always see in fishtanks keeping everything clean and beautiful. When archival staff are not attached to the pipeline, everything gets messier even more quickly.

Being attached to the pipeline affords librarians a unique and potent position on operational and management fronts. Virginia's team, now six people, manages the automation functions within BART. Their backend, KOHA, is an open-source solution managed by a vendor. Virginia was confident that, if-needed, Blizzard would go as far as forking functional software if something suddenly goes weird in their system. Their vendor contracts are even negotiated with this in mind. As for access, everything is locked down by team and every individual is their own instance with distinct privileges as needed (this was made possible thanks to the incredible support of borrowed environment engineers). Also, since they are stewarding the access pipeline, Virginia's team is also partially responsible for data leak management. Librarians with an MLIS degree are trained to maintain tracking for where information flows. They value transparency for maximum ass-covering, especially because they carry the same legal stakes that align their role with the same harms that could come to artists and dev teams. Librarians are not people to fuck with in this very specific regard. Looking at this from a non-Blizzard perspective: a library of this shape, combined with the work of a creative communications team, could strategically devalue any sort of underground leak economy by counter-programming kayfabe leaks the same way that wrestling companies historically use 'dirt-sheets' to give

podcasters light, behind-the-scenes access without really lifting a finger. For libraries and archives, this strategy is simply another access-based service. This approach could also help NDA-trapped artists and devs get portfolio-ready work that would otherwise be unreleasable out to the masses, adding yet another service to the pile of archival benefits in the game industry.

With games like World of Warcraft and Overwatch continuing to expand, being continuously online, and running the operating schedule of a 7/11 this unique team is driven to keep up with the cutting edge of technologies, server management techniques, and digital art techniques allowing them a high level of expertise that game development studios might not casually associate with librarians. I have found this approach to be elegant and inspiring, and I believe it can help a lot in aiding the most challenging parts that plague the modern game development industry. I also believe it can be scaled beyond large production houses but also to publishers managing multiple teams or as a unified service to smaller independent teams. There is so much more opportunity for librarians and archivists within games than I had ever considered before this interview.

“Our teams are so excited to have a library as a [lowkey] ‘party place’ just because so much of game development is not a party. People love us because we’re a secretive place with a lot of sensitive information. Our digital archive is the only place you can go to see work in-development, so we have to build and maintain our trust and integrity [both internally, with ABK, and with Microsoft]”

SOFTWARE VS MEDIA - AN INTERNATIONAL INCONGRUENCY

Interview with Chris Arneil - National Film and Sound Archive of Australia

‘Media’ is a vast concept that is capable of containing many different types of artwork and forms of cultural expression. Since the inception of the Australian National Film and Sound Archive in 1984, they’ve had a wide enough remit to be able to accept digital videogame material from the get-go within their archive. ‘Software’ on the other hand, is a more specific concept that narrows the space that games can occupy, in ways that conflict with artistic expression. As the 87% Report outlines, a game’s source code and materials require protections to prevent them from becoming completely inoperable in the future. But if the identity of games as software restricts the ways archives can access game materials, then how does Chris Arneil at the NFSA make it look so simple?

As Virginia put it succinctly from our previous interview, “is it preserved if it’s saved? Or if it renders?” - and public institutions have to consider, ‘is it legal for our archive to render it?’ To complicate this further, the US Library of Congress has a clause in its Recommended Formats Statement (Sect 9-C) “If a submission requires a stand-alone or proprietary platform (e.g. a gaming console or handheld device), then a virtual or emulated version of the proprietary

platform is required with submission.” This means to add a game to the LOC you would have to provide Software-For-Your-Software. This important consideration for long-term preservation is part of what makes digital games distinct from other digital media formats and associates them with software. Chris and the EU archivists focused a lot more on finished and physically published work than development materials because of this difference.

Now this is not a direct issue for the collection development policy with the VGHF because our policy explains to users why it *doesn't* contain videogame software specifically. But, this becomes an ontological issue with knock-on effects across VGHF's other services that impact this policy. Identifying these differences between US and non-US definitions of digital games/videogames and how they are archived is important when working with international organizations. It also impacts how the VGHF can advocate for best preservation practices locally by understanding how software perspective changes the way videogames are perceived.

A simple example of the difference in how games are handled is that for a media archive like Chris's, a [version identity] is not as important as it is in the epistemologically software-driven archives. Version identity is the second-to-the-top metadata listing in the LOCs guidebook - the [title] of a game is shockingly fourth, in a subsequent section below software metadata needs.

One major difference with classifying videogames as media is that it leaves fuzzy edges to what a game is that software doesn't, and I believe that is one reason why an organization like the ESA would fear how a reclassification opens things up to wider artistic expressions of game projects. I also believe this causes a conservative reaction towards defining that classification: “If you let artists have games, they'll start pushing that any interactive digital media is a videogame!” Counterpoint, I don't find the rigidity of software's classification to be all that helpful towards preservation of the work. Chris explained how easy it was for him to access a creator's works because he focuses on asking for things they've already made. This includes considerations for the final media product as opposed to the Library Of Congress needing a full compiler and code-ready version, which is a lot more invasive for the donating party. This would be alienating in different ways for large companies and small development teams. Politically, a government asking orgs for their media is vastly different from a government asking orgs for their software. One could show you sensitive information like bombs, the other can literally make bombs. But what about the main software problem Virginia brought up: having access to a game that may not have a system it can run on? Now, I might be a little biased here because I'm talking to people who are actively stewarding games, but I believe that to have only been a problem from before we had such active game stewardship: the success of emulation projects like the Internet Archive's work with Ruffle allowing effective game experiences over web interfaces has me now believing that librarian-archivists (or technologists who are undertaking the often thankless but awe-filled work of the library vocation) are very good at reverse-engineering systems at a rate that keeps up with new innovations of game technology. This, combined with regional state-sponsored stewardship like the Australian National Film and Sound Archive, can sustainably manage diverse technological archives despite missing originating architecture (something that

gamers and scholars are becoming less interested in as they accept the fall of the bulky CRT Televisions and rise of an all-digital discless medium).

To put all this simply, after talking with Chris, I'm sure I can setup a library collection of digitally accessible games that contains a curation spanning almost every known console and handheld. I've never touched a Commodore 64, or an N-Gage, the original Xbox, or a Switch 2, but I could easily find access points for these platforms. But can you ensure there will always be this level of stewardship? Yes, we should always be building forward with the assumption that we'll continue to keep emulators available on modern hardware, next question. While there is a major part of this that is currently built on unpaid labor from an incredibly enterprising and caring fandom, with a more professionalized librarian and archivist field like in Australia, development projects in this shape can only become more applied – and with grants, funded too. As Chris said about games preservation in our interview, "It's not that hard, technologically speaking. It's the people and the org rights that are the hard part."

The funnest part of a broader media scope is that Chris doesn't just collect media and hardware produced in Australia but also collections that are about Australia. While these examples are not currently added to collections, there is room for games like *Ty the Tasmanian Devil*, *Crash Bandicoot*, and *Beneath A Steel Sky* that are thematically about or set in Australia. There's also room for games and software/hardware projects made by Australians who were not formally in the country such as *Nimrod*, a computer game designed and presented at the 1951 Festival of Britain by John Makepeace Bennett. However, despite being attractive to videogame heritage for obvious reason, *Nimrod* is not considered a videogame by software-based definitions and thus would have trouble finding any kind of stewardship if it wasn't for how wide the Sight & Sound Archive's considerations have been since their inception.

Stewarding videogames as software and as media have resulted in different gaps that cause American archives to look different from their Australian and European counterparts. So what does this have to do with the VGHF, an American non-profit games media library and archive? The VGHF does not archive videogames in the way Chris Arneil's team does, but there are existential barriers for donors who might want stewardship services of their game development materials, and that stems from the US classification of games as software and not media. The VGHF's digital library users want to access games as if they are media, but are stonewalled by policies designed for software. With the VGHF continuing to advocate for games to be classified as media in order to reduce these barriers for game developers to have heritage access, they would also be able to reap the benefits of greater free-flowing access of development materials from game studios. However, this also requires a stronger definition around what a 'videogame' is, as an object, which has continued to be a fraught field stymying games studies and the industry at large. But the VGHF has unique positioning as a non-profit US public heritage institution. By straddling the public and private sectors, they can help guide that conversation towards redefining and reclassifying games as a less-biased third party who actively works within these steep limitations, stewarding a wider variety of resultant game outputs in

ways that inspire archives around the world. As Chris put it, “We [archivists] get to entirely skip the conversation ‘are games art?’”

THE LONG GAME OF DIGITAL LIBRARIES

Interview With David Pierce - Media History Digital Library

So it’s cute to talk about media stewardship lasting forever, but why do we even need librarians, really? Once a library’s materials are online and stable, why even have stewardship? Interviewing David Pierce at the Media History Digital Library (MHDL), he opened up about all the work he *doesn’t* do, but with a little hesitation in his voice because of how it’s strange to talk about something that you are vaguely responsible for but don’t necessarily do anything with. Starting with a collection in the pre-copyright era from 1963 and before, the MHDL contains every pre-1963 copyright-free commercial film, broadcasting, and radio magazine they could find from around the world. So this is a fully stable collection, but being an all-digital online archive makes it much more precarious. So how do we make sure that, as David put it, “if everyone gets hit by a bus, people can still access the raw content?”

Because the MHDL has been successful enough to be around for a few decades, they’ve gotten to see other digital libraries come and go which lead to David listing a lot of things that can go wrong and can go right when developing a digital library:

Things that can threaten the collapse of a digital library:

- Living grant-to-grant without consistent stewardship
- Rich person who sponsors no longer wants to do it
- Server update that goes unnoticed resulting in lost access
- Web hosting bills unpaid
- Everyone gets hit by a bus

Things that can prevent the collapse of a digital library:

- Planning an organization to take over stewardship such as a University or Public Institution
- Centralized web hosting with The Internet Archive: “Too big to not need data rescue services”
 - But then still embedding that hosting on an external site to show possible investors
- Contextualizing the user needs around “Digital Humanities” (or w/e terminology the Humanities are using at any given time to save their funding) - in the VGHF’s case this could include youtube and fandom-based researchers as doing humanities work
- Preparing an archive for long storage (e.g., offline backups)

- Building services for clients that leverage digitization - get 'them' to foot the bill for acquisition and labor
 - This is similar to Jason Scott conscripting DLARC to help digitize his massive tech manuals collection as many magazines were in DLARCs purview [\[link\]](#)

The main themes here are: identify your library's dependencies (the frontend and the backend) and build relationships with groups who would benefit from maintaining the collection. The journey of the MHDL starts with David's focus on copyright-free pre-'63, leading to a strong collection of material. Then the search platform, Lantern, was built by Eric Hoyt alongside Carl and Wendy Hagenmaier to contain the MHDL and make it web accessible. This connected it to the University of Madison-Wisconsin so that even after David left the project, Eric was able to manage it and ended up winning awards for the Lantern platform. For the backend, they've been with The Internet Archive since 2011, and that relationship has matured over time as IA has matured. All of this has led to an archive that can maintain itself with little worry over what will happen to the materials.

I find David's work and the philosophies baked into the MHDL to be completely analogous to where and how the VGHF has found sustainability. He identified how working with collectors on digital projects means that the collectors don't lose anything physical in this process, and how that aids in making requests to professional organizations. "If I'd asked for their movie collections, the film studios would have felt like they lost something. But since I can return their magazines after being digitized, they can still see them on their shelf and feel like nothing materially was given up but an archive of it still exists." A digital archive like the MHDL or the VGHF are elegantly set up to work with other companies and can bargain from a strong position.

David did not identify any points where he needed to return to original sources once materials were scanned. With the Media History Digital Library being about fifteen years old, I feel confident that with its current design it can easily go another fifteen before it starts needing some technological updates. It's mostly the web maintenance that seems to be the bulkiest part of maintaining a digital archive. Further, the medium of scanned digitized material itself continues to be as strong as ever and I have no doubt after talking with David and seeing his work that it will be the industry standard of archivalship for at least another 30 years (which would match microfiche's 60-ish year reign) and maybe even longer still thanks to your maintenance on those original high-quality scans!

THE REMBRANDT SELL: COMMANDMENTS FOR GAMES ARCHIVES

Interview with Willem Hilhorst - Netherlands Institute of Sound and Video

My time with Willem Hilhorst at the Netherlands Institute of Sound and Video had many echoes as to discussing their sister-organization in Australia. As games archivists inside of a

much larger institution, they had many similar roles to play. This meant our conversation focused less on format, as format was core to the Chris Arneil interview, and more about archival process. Willem discussed in great detail his styles for building archive services and selling those services to the game development communities across The Netherlands whose works span the entire history of games at all scales from AAA to indie. But the quantity to their collection is much smaller compared to other European countries and especially to the industry at large. This has led to deeper relationships with their game development community while still building access within the collection to almost every known development platform. So Willem does a lot of networking and has built up a bevy of techniques for building relationships with donors and other stakeholders.

1. [Always Check The Copyrights](#) (Thanks David Pierce!)
2. Look For The Indices - Any types of volumes that contain information about where to find other information (videogame merchandising guides for example)
3. Know how the position of your archive is understood by game developers. "People thought because we were so close to TV media that we would use their work to repeat mainstream media lines like 'games cause violence.'"
4. Plant seeds early with developers so they know what resources they will need, possibly even decades from now.
5. Connect to any regional organizations within your collection's scope, they can help reduce load, identify gaps, and advocate within their orgs for you
6. Source a historical canon of stakeholder organizations and share it around your subject's community to find gaps in your collection
7. The Rembrandt Sell: "We are expecting to archive your work for 400 years in the traditions of cultural heritage, just as we would a Rembrandt painting that may require professional upkeep to maintain research and access hundreds of years from now." Bold, for games. But it can only be said from our role - and it'll sell a service!
8. Paint the picture for developers to put it in an archival box. (The Nooney Sell)
9. Answer to your 'Demoscene': what is your subject's 'mixtape' production scene?
 - a. That cuts straight to the artists, their communities, and their creations without businesses in the way.
 - b. Always look for similar opportunities for special collections within the subject.
10. Formalize your workflow: Put it in a diagram that a future librarian could follow
11. If donor requests become too much to filter - implement a form for donors to fill out as a barrier (but consider removing it if requests lighten up, as users will understand the materials of the archive better over time)
12. If you're an archivist in a non-heritage team: give your boss a steady diet of statistics because they won't know what to ask from you. (Thanks Virginia!)
13. The Super Rembrandt Sell: If all else fails, print out a digital artist's work, frame it, and make it physical. (Thanks Virginia!)

This is a list of professional tips for games librarians and archivists that came from my conversation with Willem, but it was also influenced by all of the interviews with professionals I was able to have this year. When you walk into any of our institutions, a loading screen may appear displaying tips generated from this list. A stronger list would spread more broadly across the sides of games librarianship: Access, use, sourcing, rights management, etc. But I think this list gets across most of the stickiest parts of working in this space, especially the parts involving relationships with the wider games community. Willem is speaking from his subject expertise in The Netherlands which, while small, consistently covers the entire history of games so far – including the industry and independent sides. Speaking with Willem, I found The Netherlands to be a perfect case study for a beginner games librarian like myself, and I think that's why it can be such a strong centerpoint for games heritage as the country is so uniquely positioned for European Information Management and Infrastructure (the South Holland area; Zoetermeer, The Hague, Leiden, and even Delft happen to be hog heaven for EU Databases). I believe if Willem's subject of focus was Sweden or France, he wouldn't have the time to organize and chair any of these broader scale projects like EFGAMP.

EFGAMP AND THE PROFESSIONALIZATION OF GAMES PRESERVATION

While the commercial videogame industry around the world rapidly consolidates, the nascent heritage-sector of videogames are professionalizing in reaction. EFGAMP, the European Federation of Game Archives Museums and Preservation Projects is building unions across the European countries with the goal to have every country steward their own games histories. "If every country manages their own national heritage then we can presume that much of games history will be preserved." It's a delightfully European view that I agree is actionable for our foreseeable border-filled future. Especially because the blank spaces that become marginalized are mostly obvious (non-nationstate projects, international projects, online projects, games made beyond borders and projects hailing from Parts Unknown). Most importantly, with more heritage collaboration, members of EFGAMP can collectively unpack the trickiest edge cases inherent to this philosophy. For an overly-simplistic example, "HQ is in Warsaw, but the core Development Team was, at the time, in Oslo, so this is most appropriate to be managed by Norway. (Or Poland, until Norway gains a national archive etc.)"

Meanwhile, in the US, games heritage has begun responding to their national funding crisis by building more resilient funding models, identifying where institutions are failing to build for the longterm (preserve for 100 years and more!), and building foundational infrastructure and documentation before user/money-driving services. So by driving the conversation on how to build longer with less, US institutions have a lot to offer to conglomerating organizations like EFGAMP. But US states, Canadian provinces, and LatAm countries are not Europe - these institutions are built for independence and even carry an air of anti-dependence. Videogame preservation, especially in the US, can't look away from the Living Computer Museum's collapse

and feel safe under the pursestrings of dead billionaires like Paul Allen. When IMLS funding is callously cut every 4 to 12 years, our local heritage sectors do not reflexively look outward for institutional ties. So when an organization like the VGHF looks at EFGAMP and sees ‘oh GOG is there! Wow, 14 different countries are participating! Oh Embracer Games is there too!’ that does not ring as a clean endorsement right off the bat – although altogether in-concert definitely helps. So, what specific parts of professionalizing games preservation, building heritage along national borders, and federating games institutions are the most important for a little Star Trekian cross-continental intraplanetary alliance building?

Let’s start with the clerical details. What are all the things a North American org, like ya’self, would get -or not get- from being a satellite affiliate (aka ‘Associated Member’) of EFGAMP? I’ve read through [their full statute](#) so that you don’t have to. Associated Membership is 25€ annually. You’re allowed to attend their annual General Assembly, but the time zones will be outside of working hours. You also will be on a mostly different continental conference and convention loop, which is great for reconnecting to the EU conversations in a reliable way. You’d be a non-voting member, but you can bring topics of agenda up and build commissions with the EFGAMP group. You will also receive the annual report and General Assembly minutes. Some of that sounds good, some of that sounds tough, some of that sounds like emails, but very little of it sounds like responsibility that you would be expected to take on. From a practical standpoint, EFGAMP does not seem as if it would ask much out of an NA org in an official capacity, unless that org wanted to apply themselves. The more exciting parts are in the intangibles.

The three most prominent and professional areas that an NA org, like the VGHF, would get assistance from affiliating with EFGAMP are: Project direction, Policy sharing, and Rights management. The safest part is that the EFGAMP board knows how to pick the professional groups- if a project or policy is coming from any of these institutions you’ll be confident that those are well managed and researched initiatives coming from institutions with appropriate stakeholders that match your own. This aligns the NA and EU goals for professionalizing the industry. An interesting wrench in the system is that their projects and policies will be built around games-as-media as opposed to games-as-software, which may make those projects less appealing to a US-based organization. The worrying part to overcome is that, since the VGHF is such an independent org, this may seem like less of a mutual thing and more like many orgs asking them for help and insight representing the entire region. But that could also be all the more reason to lead the charge if there truly is that kind of demand. The toughest nut to crack though is the one that most easily aligns everyone: digital rights management. We’re all looking at this wicked problem of public ownership of digital material in a heavily privatized industry, and because of that, all librarians in the field who are responsible for managing material access end up needing to be the bridge between researchers and rights holders. And as private rights holders are consolidating into more singular organizations, I believe they will be more susceptible to requests from unionized heritage groups like EFGAMP.

So it'll require some doing, it will be a public commitment of alignment, but it brings together parts of the heritage sector with aligned interests. That's all the nitty-gritty parts that come with joining any organization. So, what are the bigger picture gains to be made here?

- Stronger ties to resources for more accurate multi-lingual or translational projects
- Leads the way for developing similar associations or wider international bridging associations.
 - Could this be expanded across NA territories?
- Stronger identification to industry stakeholders like GOG (now-independent, and self-sustaining) and Embracer Games (currently a symbol of everything wrong in game development: EU Edition - but we'll get to that because it's complicated and interesting) all of which makes EFGAMP and any of its associates look more serious
- This is similar to pro-union action that generates good press for everyone involved, and thus the wider games communities would respect it as a step towards professionalization.

WHAT USE IS A BILLIONAIRE GAMER'S ARCHIVE?

Interview with Natalia Kovalainen @ Embracer Games Archive

To end this series, we've gotta talk about Embracer Games Archive. They are a fascinating and strange archive that sits between the actual child-like dream of Collecting Every Videogame and the cold reality of the modern games industry. They have real archive stacks with the giant hand-crank wheels on them entirely full of videogames! Speaking with Natalia, the goal is very clear to have a holding for "Every Commercial Videogame Ever". Now, there isn't an end goal to this because they don't have a direct use-case for a collection of every commercial videogame, and so this is a European archive with a start-up mentality of 'build it and then we'll figure out what use it is to us.' All of this makes it sound like an evil villain plot. Normally, it is a ludicrous mission statement and a red flag for an archive to make "all" be their official policy- except, uhh, they can definitely do that. They will do that. Natalia, and her husband Jukka, are actively doing that... And to take it farther, they are probably the best people TO do it in a way where any strings that get attached with other heritage systems will be able to clearly understand the inherent risks and limitations to a private publisher-centered collection! So, I want to talk about what EGA is, how its services position itself as a European archive of a billionaire collector, some of the risks they are taking, and what the future looks like for EGA as games completely stop being physical.

Embracer Games Archive is an archive built out of a major games publisher, they are not directly connected to the creation of games like Blizzard, but Embracer's stake in the games industry is as a holding company. This puts Embracer's goals generally in alignment with the archival pursuit, and that's how EGA was tasked with building their own mission statement to 'collect all commercial videogames'. They also have control to define what 'all commercial videogames' means in terms of editions, versions, and manifestations of each individual game

they collect. Philosophically, a billionaire wanting to have every single viddygame, does align with the primary use cases of an archive: in that there will be someone to provide access to an explicitly commercial (thus purchaseable) library, it will have ALL of it (only about 50 years of recent history with decreasing remit due to market going digital - no need for Steam), and it will be in Embracer Games' business interest to search at the edges of this remit (the european demoscene). So while it may seem risky on the outside to uphold a billionaire's archive in an archive space where we've seen so many other billionaires historically fall (Paul Allen), I have reason to believe in Lars Wingefors's vision for designing a space that can run for 100s of years. First of all, Wingefors is too young to be thinking purely of legacy, which means he has a unique business interest in the EGA and, barring scandal, he'll be around to oversee things for some time. Second, there are just enough guidelines on the scope of the collection to believe that the goal is possible, especially now that the entire scope of physical commercial releases will be foreseeably locked at 60 years. Finally, it's generally been a net-good to have a European-style [REMIT: 1 of ALL] library like this (Svalbard Global Seed Vault) and there are plenty of European private archives that historically succeeded when the owner had more money than God. Of course, there's some important sticking points and inevitable risks to this as a private venture too.

While tech libraries like Microsoft closing down could have knock-on effects on a living library-archive like Blizzard, they affect a holding company's private archive in a different way. Despite both being private software-based collections, they have completely different corporate evaluations involved which means where Microsoft would flippantly decide to shut down their library, EGA would have no reason to make the same move. Why? Well the funny little secret is that: The EGA is not a part of the Embracer Group. It is a subsidiary org just like any of Embracer's game companies! This allows them the freedom to define their own mission and terms, but it also means they could, at any point, be sucked dry in the exact same way these major games holding companies are currently vampiring their own games studios. This feels like a very uncommon relationship between heritage and owner. I can't think of a similar ownership structure to that from historical archives because so often our heritage is a rich guy that wants his name on a building after he dies, but this inherently risks all of that. If Wingefors, [known hotdog man](#), is flung from Embracer, the EGA would not go with him. But I also don't see the EGA ever getting evaluated on their spreadsheets similarly to tens-to-hundreds of massive games companies that all fluctuate way more wildly at any given time. All of this is to say: I believe the EGA is in a strong spot right now. They only have three employees with which to show up and show out how powerful a modern archive can be without being seen as any kind of risk in the way Embracer Group is used to. They are safe because they are not directly attached, AND they gain some unique freedoms with less board-room scrutiny because they are disconnected from the central org and in that sense are treated like an extremely stable holding. All of this also explains how Natalia and the gang landed on Commercial Games as primary remit. Other similarly-positioned archives could position themselves closer to game development itself to better manage teams. It's just way easier and less rights-intensive to

collect games you can buy off the shelf¹. But if you aren't attached to /any/ of the other teams in your mega-organization and it is continuing to grow through acquisitions, then if you are the EGA you can expect to continue to increase in size for some time. And then there's the worst-case scenario, what if the parent company Embracer goes under, or sells? Can the EGA go independent like GOG?

As much as I love speculating on a dear heritage site's survivability, but let's talk about something way cooler: library policies! The stakes are clear, but what do they do? The EGA has a collection of 80k games, and many of those are unique entries as their policy is to avoid duplicates unless it is for unique special editions or there is seen to be some historical value to multiple versions (version exclusives on disc or distinct regional differences - Pokemon Red, Blue, Green-JP etc). It sounds like the main drive is to provide an accurate experience to what most gamers local to Sweden played (or wished they played - which I believe would cause some interesting gaps). This means they manage a lot of metadata centered around their specific manifestation of a game's commercial positioning - including scanned imaging of the boxes and packaging materials. They are available to some public individuals and groups if their usage request makes sense, and the EGA currently gets about two or three visitors/groups a week. These range from young school groups to professional research teams. The EGA wholly owns their wide collection of commercial consoles and PCs appropriate to the area, as they always try to support and curate original hardware usage with their collection. EGA brought in Plaion's archive when they went out of business, which expanded the collection by 10,000. That expansion included every printed regional version of every Plaion game, which is not barred by their policy, but it does make for a strange chunk of the collection.

As a private company, the outward services come ahead of the internal services, which can make things chaotic. Normally, this would make me nervous, but Natalia and Jukka at one point re-organized the entire archive to go from accession order to platform order [Atari section/Sony section/etc] in about a month - they are proven stalwart warrior-stewards against the chaos. So, at least for now, the people working the EGA can handle the largely unknowable workload. They have already doubled their starting collection size in four years of work, and are continuing to set the bar for collection size. "We are eating the elephant one bite at a time."

¹ However, I can imagine the pull of a publisher wanting the dev teams they manage to supply all assets and documents to a centralized information management system. That way they would be attached directly to the production from a different company... Late capitalist librarianship...

Here's a non-exhaustive list of the core metadata that EGA is currently capturing [NOTE: It's specific to the artifact itself]:

- Associated Acquisition + Collection Name
- Game Title
- Game Type (E.g., Single Game, Games bundle, Special Edition)
- Language
- Region
- Physical Format
- Localisation
- Geographical Region
- Content
- Acquisition (related)
- Location + Location History
- Permanent UUIDs
- Full front + back + inside images (w/ measurements)
 - Standardized imaging practices of game objects
- Thesaurus for collection standardization

Thesaurus

Search [v] Items [v] Features [v] Permanent ID registration [v]

☐ term	term.type	term.status
☐ Bandai Sufami Turbo	platform	candidate
☐ Bandai Super Vision 8000	platform	approved preferred term
☐ Bandai Video Challenger	platform	approved preferred term
☐ Bandai WonderSwan	platform	approved preferred term
☐ Bandai WonderSwan Color	platform	approved preferred term
☐ Battery acid leakage	check/assessment reason	candidate
☐ BBC Master	platform	candidate
☐ BBC Micro	platform	candidate
☐ Benelux	localisation	candidate
☐ Benesse Pocket Challenge W	platform	candidate
☐ Bit Corporation BIT90	platform	candidate
☐ Bit Corporation Gamate	platform	approved preferred term
☐ Blaze Entertainment Evercade	platform	candidate
☐ Blu-ray	physical format	approved preferred term
☐ Bought - Auction	acquisition method	approved preferred term
☐ Bought - Contract	acquisition method	approved preferred term
☐ Bought - Receipt	acquisition method	approved preferred term
☐ Brazil	localisation	candidate
☐ C64	platform	approved non preferred term
☐ Cadaco Buzztime Trivia Game System	platform	approved preferred term
☐ Canada	localisation	candidate
☐ Card	physical format	approved preferred term
☐ Cartridge	physical format	approved preferred term
☐ Casio Loopy	platform	approved preferred term
☐ Casio PV-1000	platform	approved preferred term

Page 3 of 18 [all sort by ascending] 442 Records, 0 Marked

This example of Embracer's Thesaurus shows a good range of archival priorities and formats

I have some concern with their metadata capture practices as they don't seem to have any standardizations or a known schema to rely on. Normally that would make this metadata be less applicable outside of the EGAs context, but since Natalia also is one of the board members of EFGAMP, they may be driving standardization practices that will be in conversation with the other European heritage sites. This billionaire's metadata feels shallow, and without strong metadata practices they can't anchor their collection as strongly to a national information share. At the same time, simple metadata may help museums who don't specialize in videogames but may host them in some capacity. So it could still be a launching off point for a young archive. It is so focused on the physical aspect and it seems to disengage from the digital/software aspect. So, this isn't metadata around just any game, it's specifically metadata about their held copy. There's so much to cover from any given artifact itself, and without wider direction it makes sense to start with the physical features so you can find it on a shelf. Librarian lifetimes can be spent just analyzing and building metadata for the physical parts of games: the box it came in, the paper materials, the disc quality, etc. But it definitely comes from the archive being driven by a collector's mentality. Why do they work so hard to scan and digitize receipts or hand-written notes? I believe it is because that is what makes EGA's copy special – it also uncovers some vital played history too which is neat (did you ever, as a kid, take a game's instruction booklet to school and just read it over and over?), but it more specifically turns their commercial copy into a I-of-I. Especially if they end up with materials from someone who is or became famous in a field. That is how stewards can mine private value from a physical collection in a way that sells well to someone like Lars Wingefors while also doing some impactful historical work while these artifacts are still young (relatively).

Overall, I find Embracer Games Archive as low-risk and stable of an endeavor as any games archive could be. They have the fundamentals, the resources, and a high quality of stewardship that drives towards community and expertise building. If there is a use for this kind of archive, I'm sure they'll figure many of them out. The mix of classical 'European collection development strategies inspired by wacky rich dudes' works well with our industry's modern drive for professionalization and community. There is still a lack of direction that shows up in their metadata practices, the fear that it could all fall away due to shaky private business practices within late capitalism, and without any more physical games they will be able to park their full collection as it increases in value. As one of the major players within EFGAMP that could have friction with the various national archives (they DO want to embrace every videogame... Including Yours, if possible) many of those types of worries were assuaged talking with Natalia, and it makes me all the more confident with how the VGHF can support both EGAs mission (without needing to automatically cape for Embracer Games itself since they are a distinct subsidiary) as well as take many notes from how they move over the next few years as they are in a position to explore a wide variety of services from the increasingly rare Industry Mega-Publisher point-of-view. For one example, they have a goal to become the largest archive for the European Demoscene. While the collection services are strong, they are still searching for different audiences and usergroups within Sweden. While we spoke, Natalia's very next meeting was to plan a 100-teacher summer outing to see what they will need. Whatever they need or

use throughout that visit will be data used for future policy development as well as data for future investment.

Also, because I think it's hilarious and fascinating: their collections budget *has* been decreasing over the last year as a direct result of the end of physical releases (and they are still formally collecting the new codes-in-boxes too, which is ironically probably going to age very well for their collection) - that money has continually been put back into historical acquisition instead. What a weird world!

BACKENDS

Everyone asked during this process reported that there is little difficulty about managing games collections within their backends, but all have continually looked at growing or changing their management systems with games in mind after those materials start being added. "Growing out of Reading Rooms" is a metaphor Chris Arneil used to describe that the old systems fit videogames well but can also be improved on with the help of games.

Virginia Allison-Reinhardt: **Koha** - open source digital management system. Recently moved their system over about two years ago. That migration project took in total about 3 months of time.

Chris Arneil: **Mediaflex** - media asset management that does physical and digital in the same place. Easy to associate digital assets with a physical hanger on a shelf (Note: Working on a new digital asset management system)

David Pierce: **Lantern** - Developed by David Hoyt at the University of Wisconsin-Madison who adopted the MHDL. Extends digital assets with simple metadata management and associates them with Internet Archive's hosting

Natalia Kovalainen: **Axiell** - European museum standard. Not explicitly made for games, but can manage the immediate needs of Embracer Games Archive. Used for Manifestation-level archiving, down to including scans of any physical receipts or hand-written notes found with their copy of the game.

AI-USAGE IN ARCHIVES

Both private archives I spoke with, Embracer and Blizzard, have AI policies in place for the things they make that the archivists use to drive how they use genAI. They both agreed that the uses they've found for genAI have been extremely helpful for their jobs and they both use it the exact same ways:

Uses for genAI in games librarianship:

- Identifying objects in images
- [End Of List]

The algorithmic tagging of images is the primary use of genAI in games libraries. The workers still have to manually scan all images and generated tags to make sure the tags are fine, but this is work that is otherwise not often completed in an urgent library setting and is done much faster with the help of algorithmic image identification. The main protocol that comes with genAI-based tagging is that both archives must maintain all original images and non-AI tags in a separate state, in case a stronger algorithm comes along that can be applied to images. As much as I don't condone AI anywhere near information manipulation, this is a sensible use-case that leverages a well-understood algorithm for a job that will otherwise never be done. And if every AI company suddenly collapses, this usage will easily be able to adapt and move forward from its algorithmic base in a way that will not be hampered by technological upheaval.

I don't have much else to offer in this section – this is more of an ancillary observation to the more important policy investigation happening at the time. Embracer Games Archive also uses some AI to do deeper cross-referential searching using their database, which as described sounded like a combination of algorithmic google searching along with a SQL query. That's what librarians have always done and the AI-part came off as a semantic 'of-the-times' type of admission. I've taken all of this to signal that genAI has not had much of an effect on games library work. I don't want to brag because I wish there were more tools to make our job easier, but AI has failed to assist modern information stewardship, and I find that an ultimate damnation for how disruptive and pervasive it has been everywhere else. Technology has done a lot over the last century to transform information management with librarians driving those innovations, and where genAI should be transforming things the most – a videogame library – it isn't.